MAJORS & MINDSETS · FRESHMAN ACADEMY

How do you *open a can?*

You don’t know what you don’t know



Pedram Jahangiry
Data Analytics & Information Systems

HUNTSMAN SCHOOL OF BUSINESS · NOV 13, 2026

A physicist, a chemist and an economist

are stranded on an island.

One can of food. No can opener.



“Let’s assume we have a can opener.”

THE ECONOMIST

(I’m an economist. I spent six years of a PhD learning to assume can openers.)

I’ve changed “majors” too

THEN

Economics

PhD. Six years of assumptions.

→

THEN

Finance

BlackRock. Models with real money.

→

NOW

Data

Analytics & Information Systems

What my best colleagues shared wasn’t a major. **It was a way of thinking.**

You don’t know what you don’t know

Known knowns

A business needs customers and money.

Known unknowns

“What does an Information Systems major actually do?”

Unknown knowns

You might already think like an accountant. You just don’t know it yet.

Unknown unknowns

The questions you don’t even know to ask. Jobs that don’t exist yet.

PHONES OUT. YES, REALLY.

Let’s collect some data. *Right now.*

5 questions

60 seconds

Anonymous

pedramjahangiry.com/polls/mindsets

This room, right now

Open the live results ↗

Mindsets in this room · % numbers people · 8:30 vs 9:30

TURN AND TALK · 30 SEC

Tell your neighbor your result.

Did it get you right? Why or why not?

How long did that take to build?



You don’t know what Supabase or GitHub Pages are. That’s fine. **You understood the idea.**

A FEW YEARS AGO

A team of developers
A semester
A budget

THIS FALL

One professor
14 minutes
AI

The can opener is *real.*

So what’s still hard?

1

Ask a sharp question

Not “what major?” but “what do I actually like doing?”

2

Find the data that answers it

Your answers, from 200 people, in 60 seconds.

3

Check whether you’re wrong

The result that missed is the most useful one.

That’s the data mindset. **AI opens the can. You decide which can.**

Data × every major

Accounting × *data*

Catch the odd transaction before the auditor does.

Pro Sales & Marketing × *data*

Know which customer to call first, and which ad actually worked.

Management × *data*

See what's really working on your team, not just what feels like it.

Econ & Finance × *data*

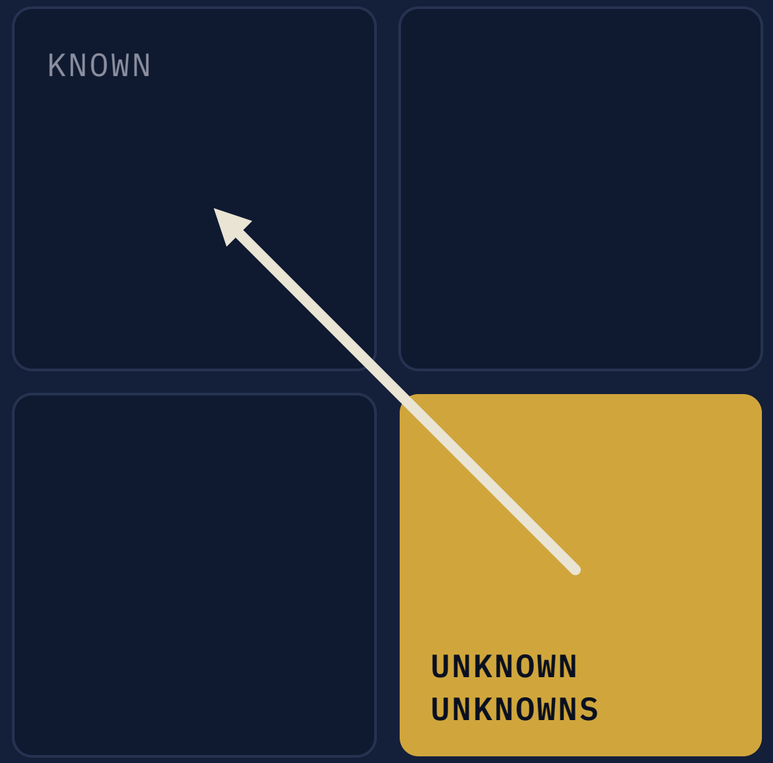
Test the theory and the strategy before you bet the money.

Major or minor, **data multiplies whatever you pick.**

Feeling a little scared about AI?

You’re not alone. So are the experts.

Fear lives in the unknown unknowns. **Curiosity is how you move things out.**



You don’t have to assume the can opener anymore.

What will you *open?*



Retake it. Share it.